DISTRESS TOLERANCE SESSION 7

Radical Acceptance
Turning the Mind (Using Half-Smile and Willing Hands)
Willingness

Overview:
Reality Acceptance Skills

These are skills for how to live a life that is not the life you want.

RADICAL ACCEPTANCE

TURNING THE MIND

WILLINGNESS

HALF-SMILING AND WILLING HANDS

**ALLOWING THE MIND:
MINDFULNESS OF CURRENT THOUGHTS**

Radical Acceptance

(When you cannot keep painful events and emotions from coming your way.)

WHAT IS RADICAL ACCEPTANCE?

1. Radical means *all the way*, complete and total.
2. It is accepting in your mind, your heart, and your body.
3. It's when you stop fighting reality, stop throwing tantrums because reality is not the way you want it, and let go of bitterness.

WHAT HAS TO BE ACCEPTED?

1. Reality is as it is (the facts about the past and the present are the facts, even if you don't like them).
2. There are limitations on the future for everyone (but only realistic limitations need to be accepted).
3. Everything has a cause (including events and situations that cause you pain and suffering).
4. Life can be worth living even with painful events in it.

WHY ACCEPT REALITY?

1. Rejecting reality does not change reality.
2. Changing reality requires first accepting reality.
3. Pain can't be avoided; it is nature's way of signaling that something is wrong.
4. Rejecting reality turns pain into suffering.
5. Refusing to accept reality can keep you stuck in unhappiness, bitterness, anger, sadness, shame, or other painful emotions.
6. Acceptance may lead to sadness, but deep calmness usually follows.
7. The path out of hell is through misery. By refusing to accept the misery that is part of climbing out of hell, you fall back into hell.

Turning the Mind

TURNING THE MIND is like facing a fork in the road. You have to turn your mind toward the acceptance road, and away from the road of rejecting reality.

TURNING THE MIND is choosing to accept.

The CHOICE to accept does not itself equal acceptance. It just puts you on the path.

TURNING THE MIND, STEP BY STEP

1. **OBSERVE** that you are not accepting. (Look for anger, bitterness, annoyance; avoiding emotions; saying "Why me?", "Why is this happening?", "I can't stand this," "It shouldn't be this way.")
2. Go within yourself and **MAKE AN INNER COMMITMENT** to accept reality as it is.
3. **DO IT AGAIN,** over and over. Keep turning your mind to acceptance each time you come to the fork in the road where you can reject reality or accept it.
4. **DEVELOP A PLAN** for catching yourself in the future when you drift out of acceptance.

Willingness

Willingness is readiness to enter and participate fully in life and living.

Find a WILLING RESPONSE to each situation.

Willingness is DOING JUST WHAT IS NEEDED:

- In each situation.
- Wholeheartedly, without dragging your feet.

Willingness is listening very carefully to your WISE MIND, and then acting from your WISE MIND.

Willingness is ACTING WITH AWARENESS that you are connected to the universe (to the stars, people you like and don't like, the floor, etc.).

Replace WILLFULNESS with WILLINGNESS.

- Willfulness is **REFUSING TO TOLERATE** the moment.
- Willfulness is refusing to make changes that are needed.
- Willfulness is **GIVING UP.**
- Willfulness is the **OPPOSITE OF "DOING WHAT WORKS."**
- Willfulness is trying to **FIX EVERY SITUATION.**
- Willfulness is insisting on **BEING IN CONTROL.**
- Willfulness is **ATTACHMENT TO "ME, ME, ME"** and "what I want right now!"

WILLINGNESS, STEP BY STEP

1. **OBSERVE** the willfulness. Label it. Experience it.
2. **RADICALLY ACCEPT** that at this moment you feel (and may be acting) willful. You can not fight willfulness with willfulness.
3. **TURN YOUR MIND** toward acceptance and willingness.
4. **Try HALF-SMILING** and a **WILLING POSTURE.**
5. When willfulness is immovable, **ASK, "WHAT'S THE THREAT?"**

Situations where I notice my own:

Willfulness:_____

Willingness: _____

Half-Smiling and Willing Hands

Accepting reality with your body.

HALF-SMILING

1st. *Relax* your face from the top of your head down to your chin and jaw.

Let go of each facial muscle (forehead, eyes, and brows; cheeks, mouth, and tongue; teeth slightly apart). If you have try tensing your facial muscles and then letting go.

A tense smile is a grin (and might tell your brain you are hiding or masking your real feelings).

2nd. Let both *corners of your lips* go slightly up, just so you can feel them.

It is not necessary for others to see it. A half-smile is slightly upturned lips with a relaxed face.

3rd. Try to adopt a serene facial expression.

Remember, your face communicates to your brain; your body connects to your mind

WILLING HANDS

Standing: Drop your arms down from your shoulders; keep them straight or bent slightly at the elbows. With hands unclenched, turn your hands outward, with thumbs out to your sides, palms up, and fingers relaxed.

Sitting: Place your hands on your lap or your thighs. With hands unclenched, turn your hands outward, with palms up and fingers relaxed.

Lying down: Arms by your side, hands unclenched, turn your palms up with fingers relaxed.

Remember, your hands communicate to your brain; your body connects to your mind.

DISTRESS TOLERANCE WORKSHEET 9 (Distress Tolerance Handouts 11–11b)

Radical Acceptance

Due Date: _____ Name: _____ Week Starting: _____

FIGURE OUT WHAT YOU NEED TO RADICALLY ACCEPT

1. Make a list of two **very important** things in your life right now that you need to radically accept. Then give each one a number indicating how much you accept this part of yourself or your life: from 0 (no acceptance, I am in complete denial and/or rebellion) to 5 (complete acceptance, I am at peace with this). *Note:* if you have already completed this section, you don't need to do it again unless things have changed.

What I need to accept (Acceptance, 0–5)

1. _____ (_____)

2. _____ (_____)

2. Make a list of two **less important** things in your life you are having trouble accepting this week. Then rate your acceptance just as you did above.

What I need to accept (Acceptance, 0–5)

1. _____ (_____)

2. _____ (_____)

REFINE YOUR LIST

3. Review your two lists above. **Check the facts.** Check for interpretations and opinions. Make sure that what you are trying to accept is in fact the case. **Check for judgments.** Avoid "good," "bad," and judgmental language. Rewrite any items above if needed so that they are **factual and nonjudgmental.**

PRACTICE RADICAL ACCEPTANCE

4. Choose one item from the very important list and one item from the less important list to practice on.

1. _____

2. _____

5. Focus your mind on each of these facts or events separately, allowing your Wise Mind to radically accept that these *are* facts of your life. *Check off* any of the following exercises that you did.

- ❑ Observed that I was questioning or fighting reality.
- ❑ Reminded myself that reality is what it is.
- ❑ Considered the causes of the reality, and nonjudgmentally accepted that causes exist.
- ❑ Practiced accepting all the way with my whole being (mind, body, spirit).
- ❑ Practiced opposite action.
- ❑ Coped ahead with events that seemed unacceptable.
- ❑ Attended to my body sensations as I thought about what I need to accept.
- ❑ Allowed myself to experience disappointment, sadness, or grief.
- ❑ Acknowledged that life can be worth living even when there is pain.
- ❑ Did pros and cons of accepting versus denial and rejection.
- ❑ Other: _____ _____

6. Rate your degree of acceptance after practicing radical acceptance (0–5): _____

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DISTRESS TOLERANCE WORKSHEET 9 (Distress Tolerance Handouts 11–11b)

Radical Acceptance

Due Date: _____ Name: _____ Week Starting: _____

FIGURE OUT WHAT YOU NEED TO RADICALLY ACCEPT

1. Make a list of two **very important** things in your life right now that you need to radically accept. Then give each one a number indicating how much you accept this part of yourself or your life: from 0 (no acceptance, I am in complete denial and/or rebellion) to 5 (complete acceptance, I am at peace with this). *Note:* if you have already completed this section, you don't need to do it again unless things have changed.

What I need to accept (Acceptance, 0–5)

1. _____ (_____)

2. _____ (_____)

2. Make a list of two **less important** things in your life you are having trouble accepting this week. Then rate your acceptance just as you did above.

What I need to accept (Acceptance, 0–5)

1. _____ (_____)

2. _____ (_____)

REFINE YOUR LIST

3. Review your two lists above. **Check the facts.** Check for interpretations and opinions. Make sure that what you are trying to accept is in fact the case. **Check for judgments.** Avoid "good," "bad," and judgmental language. Rewrite any items above if needed so that they are **factual and nonjudgmental.**

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- ❑ Observed that I was questioning or fighting reality.
- ❑ Reminded myself that reality is what it is.
- ❑ Considered the causes of the reality, and nonjudgmentally accepted that causes exist.
- ❑ Practiced accepting all the way with my whole being (mind, body, spirit).
- ❑ Practiced opposite action.
- ❑ Coped ahead with events that seemed unacceptable.
- ❑ Attended to my body sensations as I thought about what I need to accept.
- ❑ Allowed myself to experience disappointment, sadness, or grief.
- ❑ Acknowledged that life can be worth living even when there is pain.
- ❑ Did pros and cons of accepting versus denial and rejection.
- ❑ Other: _____

6. Rate your degree of acceptance after practicing radical acceptance (0–5): _____

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DISTRESS TOLERANCE WORKSHEET 9A (Distress Tolerance Handouts 11–11b)

Practicing Radical Acceptance

Due Date: _____ Name: _____ Week Starting: _____

Practice each skill twice, and describe and rate your experience below.

When did you practice this skill, and what did you do to practice?	What was going on that you had trouble accepting (if anything)?	How long did you practice accepting?	Rate before/after skill use			Conclusions or questions about this skills practice
			Acceptance (0 = none at all; 5 = I am at peace with this)	Emotion		
				Negative emotion intensity (0–100)	Positive emotion intensity (0–100)	
Considered causes of the reality:			/	/	/	
			/	/	/	
Practiced with my whole self:			/	/	/	
			/	/	/	
Practiced opposite action:			/	/	/	
			/	/	/	
Practiced coping ahead:			/	/	/	
			/	/	/	
Attended to body sensations:			/	/	/	
			/	/	/	
Allowed disappointment/grieving:			/	/	/	
			/	/	/	
Acknowledged life as worth living:			/	/	/	
			/	/	/	
Did pros and cons:			/	/	/	
			/	/	/	

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DISTRESS TOLERANCE WORKSHEET 10 (Distress Tolerance Handouts 12, 13)

Turning the Mind, Willingness, Willfulness

Due Date: _____ Name: _____ Week Starting: _____

Practice each skill, and rate your level of acceptance of reality as it is before and after: from 0 (no acceptance at all) to 5 (I'm at peace with this). List what you tried specifically under the rating.

Turning the Mind: Acceptance Before: _____ After: _____

OBSERVE not accepting. What did you observe? What were you having trouble accepting?

MAKE AN INNER COMMITMENT to accept what feels unacceptable. How did you do this?

Describe your **PLAN FOR CATCHING YOURSELF** the next time you drift from acceptance.

WILLINGNESS (rate 0–5): Acceptance Before: _____ After: _____
Willfulness Before: _____ After: _____

Describe **EFFECTIVE BEHAVIOR** you did to move forward toward a goal.

NOTICE WILLFULNESS. Describe how you are not participating effectively in the world as it is, or how you are not doing something you know needs to be done to move toward a goal.

Describe how you **PRACTICED RADICALLY ACCEPTING YOUR WILLFULNESS.**

MAKE AN INNER COMMITMENT to accept what feels unacceptable. How did you do this?

Describe what you did that was **WILLING.**

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Half-Smiling and Willing Hands

Due Date: _____ Name: _____ Week Starting: _____

Describe your practice with half-smiling and willing hands this past week. Practice each day at least once. Practice both when you are not emotionally distressed and when you are distressed.

Check off any of the following exercises that you did.

- ❑ 1. Half-smiled when I first woke up in the morning.
- ❑ 2. Half-smiled during my free moments.
- ❑ 3. Half-smiled with willing hands while I was listening to music.
- ❑ 4. Half-smiled with willing hands when I was irritated.
- ❑ 5. Half-smiled in a lying-down position.
- ❑ 6. Half-smiled in a sitting position.
- ❑ 7. Half-smiled when I was walking down the street.
- ❑ 8. Half-smiled with willing hands when my feelings were hurt.
- ❑ 9. Half-smiled with willing hands when I did not want to accept something.
- ❑ 10. Half-smiled with willing hands when I started getting really angry.
- ❑ 11. Half-smiled when I had negative thoughts.
- ❑ 12. Half-smiled when I couldn't sleep.
- ❑ 13. Half-smiled with another person.
- ❑ 14. Other: _____

_____

Describe practicing half-smiling and willing hands.

1. Situation: _____

Describe strategies you used or give numbers from above: _____

Circle how effective this was at helping you be more mindful and less reactive:

1	2	3	4	5
Not effective		*Somewhat effective*		*Very effective*

2. Situation: _____

Describe strategies you used or give numbers from above: _____

Circle how effective this was at helping you be more mindful and less reactive:

1	2	3	4	5
Not effective		*Somewhat effective*		*Very effective*

3. Situation: _____

Describe strategies you used or give numbers from above: _____

Circle how effective this was at helping you be more mindful and less reactive:

1	2	3	4	5
Not effective		*Somewhat effective*		*Very effective*

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